NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 06

Looong live Master Giovanni!

Author

Adelbert Vervloet

Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus ≈ 100 min read aloud
Scenes	21 (+ 1 visual interlude)
Version	2026-09-23 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne

Episode 06 — Looong live Master Giovanni!

Author Adelbert Vervloet

Logline

At the Lake of Rage, an ungainly capture. Lance the Champion watches and does not approach. Flashbacks: a hollow title, Green, reform. Then the cry: Looong live Master Giovanni. Charizard at the lake. In Goldenrod, the snow and the bark.

Place in the arc

Due: two Lances; Coyote; Dex as guard; Red's disappearance.

Paid: red Gyarados; humanised Elite Four; ventriloquist Murkrow; tempered flame.

Open: message to Giovanni; Houndoom off-screen; Athena.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Gold/Richter	Curse / Mean Look / Heavy Ball; crop
Lance (Champion)	≠ Team Rocket executive. Lake shadows; reform
Clair	Blackthorn terrace — single spelling
Red / Green / Misty	Title; trial; Viridian
Silver	Feraligatr = gentilic
Murkrow / Lambda	Cry; travesty

Places (EN anchors)

Lake of Rage · Blackthorn · Indigo Plateau · Mahogany · Goldenrod Radio Tower.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Taken from the manuscript. The narrative does not repeat them.

Lake of Rage — why not Surf

The "normal" approach (Surf + battle on the water): suicide. Target too conspicuous. Derivative flight strips away half one's concentration. An ungainly, less seemly, effective norm: the bank, Haunter (Curse, Mean Look), Heavy Ball struck with the hunting crop. Even plunged, Gold/Richter would not move faster than this red Gyarados. Haunter may look unsavoury; it contains a colossal body.

Move modification

Pursuit power raised from 40 to 80, to intensify the risk of being read during a recall. Power also doubled against those who flee.

Alignment —

Aerodactyl is not anatomically capable of producing rocks on its own. It is a Pokémon resurrected from a fossil. The Rock type is not its original type. Therefore, Aerodactyl does not possess moves such as Stone Edge, nor moves that cause environmental damage such as Earthquake.

Heading	Note — raid / cry
Murkrow	Level 33. Haze cancels Agility. Night Shade = warning to Charizard. Cry: Looong live Master Giovanni!
Raticate	Level 27. Hyper Fang, Crunch, Sucker Punch. Target: the human and Fearow.
Gold/Richter's Pokémon	Level 32–33
Grunts / scientists	Level 19–24. Porygon 30 — the individual at the Radio Tower in GSC and HGSS.
Relay	Charizard takes over from Aerodactyl: PP and weariness. Charizard's speed sets the cadence.
Crops	hunting crop only. Never whip / cane.
Gentilic	a gentilic starter — not gentle. In dialogue: my gentilic (Feraligatr).

Battle references

The walking hunt	Richter Belmont and Annette hunt vampires in Paris EP05 S02
Visceral antagonism	Alucard vs the walking vampires in Paris EP05 S02

Screen durations (excluding titles)

A Hollow Title ≈ 1 min. Acerbic announcement ≈ 45–60 s. Birth of a champion ≈ 45–60 s. I Await Your Challenge < 2 min. Wavering favour 20–25 s. Ascent (interlude) 12–15 s.

Two Lances

Here: Champion ワタル. The Team Rocket executive (ランス) remains the other — already noted in eps. 03 and 05.

BGM index — pieces (OST)

Scene	Piece	Span
Lake of Rage	Heavenly Father	02:04 · 04:04 · 04:55–end
Capture (effect)	Fire It Is	01:50–01:54
Isolated values	Rebellion	until ~01:12
Acerbic announcement	Powerful Predatory Deadly	03:08–end
Birth of a champion	Family in Heart	entry
Election anxiety	She Who Mauls	02:12–02:38
Looong live…	Your Choice	02:38 · 03:26
Guardian / god	Please Don’t Leave Me	entry · 00:35

BGM index — traces

Address only.

Scene	BGM
A Hollow Title	EP02 S01 15:30–16:06
You Won’t Regret It	EP01 S02 19:53–20:33
A gentilic starter	EP05 S02 01:20–02:48
A gentilic starter	EP01 S02 16:46–17:00
Flame tempered	EP01 S02 04:30–05:40
Flame tempered	EP03 S02 08:10–08:50
Flame tempered	EP06 S01 09:00–09:58

Order of scenes

1. This Time, Darkness Cannot Eclipse This World
2. Isolated Values
3. A Hollow Title
4. The Acerbic Announcement

5. The Painful Birth of a Champion

6. You Won’t Regret It

7. Election Anxiety

8. I Await Your Challenge

9. The Wavering Favour

10. Misunderstanding. Paradoxical Declaration

11. You Would Have Wanted It to Be Him?

12. Warrior, Scientist and Politician

13. The Reform of the Elite Four

14. The Ascent (visual interlude)

15. The Spreading Shadow

16. An Obscene Travesty

17. The Walking Hunt

18. Visceral Antagonism

19. Looong live Master Giovanni!

20. A Gentilic Starter

21. The Flame Tempered by Water

22. The Guardian of Hell and the God of Death

The scenes are inserted here. The close follows the body.

Scene – This time, darkness cannot eclipse this world

Lake of Rage

BGM: *'Heavenly* Father' from 02:04

The wind blew in from the lake in short, cold gusts. Gold/Richter's feet were sunk in the mud up to his ankles. He could hardly feel his toes any more. He kept his eyes fixed on the black water, barely blinking. He flew off over the lake, grabbing hold of Fearow's leg.

Fearow dived again. Always the same cry, always the same movement. The red Gyarados raised its head each time, as if it could not do otherwise. It had already tried to dive two or three times. With each attempt, its body had stiffened further, as if something were pulling it back from within.

Haunter was floating near the bank, almost skimming the water's surface. Its body trembled at times, very slightly. Haunter had cast the ***Curse*** spell a moment earlier. You could now see the Gyarados tensing up even more whenever it moved. Its movements had become slower, heavier. Every time it strained to dive, it looked as though something were tearing at its insides from below.

When the Gyarados tried to take revenge on Haunter with a shot of Dragon Rage, Gold/Richter had it attack in order to cover his Haunter, as a diversion.

Gold/Richter raised the Hunting Crop slightly. A sharp crack rang out through the damp air. Fearow changed its angle and dived lower, forcing the Gyarados to turn its head even further skywards. The enraged beast unleashed a Twister that made the air tremble, but Fearow narrowly avoided it. A moment later, a spray of water and Dragon Rage exploded where the bird had been a second earlier.

The Gyarados tried again. It plunged halfway into the dark water, then came to an abrupt halt. Its body stiffened violently. It reared back, mouth agape, as if the water itself had pushed it away. It remained there, half its body out of the water, gasping for breath.

Haunter moved forward a little. Its gaze fell upon him. ***Mean Look***.

The Gyarados did not dive any further. It remained stuck, agitated, unable to sink. The water around it seemed thicker, more resistant. It kept trying to force its way through, but its body no longer responded as it had before. It remained on the surface, exposed, breathing heavily.

BGM: *'Heavenly* Father' from 04:04

Gold/Richter drew a Heavy Ball. The metal felt cold against his palm. He did not bother to find a good stance. He took a step back into the mud, tossed the ball into the air without any particular momentum, and struck it.

The hunting crop cracked once, sharply.

The ball flew forwards, heavy and ungainly. It cut through the air above the water.

BGM effect 'Fire It Is' 01:50–01:54

The Gyarados saw it coming.

It did not scream. It did not even really struggle. Something in its yellow gaze simply shattered. It realised, at the very last moment, that this thing flying towards it was not just another attack. It was

an end. A closing. It would never be able to dive again. It would never be able to escape again. It remained there, half out of the water, watching the ball approach.

Lance, the champion, watched from behind the trees, at a distance.

BGM: *'Heavenly* Father' from 04:55 to the end

He had not moved since the start. He had watched the young Trainer arrive alone on the riverbank, cast the curse, block the escape route, then strike the ball with his hunting crop without haste or triumph.

He tightened his grip slightly.

'Perhaps this time, the darkness cannot eclipse this world…'

He remained in the shadows. He did not approach.

The Murkrow, perched in the bare branches of a dead tree, watched the surface of the lake for a moment longer. Then it flew off without a cry, heading towards Mahogany Town.

(Chorus of Horror – Heavenly Father)
End of scene

Scene – Isolated Values

Blackthorn – A small stone terrace at the back of a family home, set on high ground. Twilight.

BGM 'Rebellion' (until ~01:12)

The wind blew intermittently through the mountains. The light was fading rapidly, casting a cold grey hue over the stones of the terrace. In the distance, the peaks were beginning to fade into the darkness. It was already chilly. Clair stood near the low stone wall, arms crossed, hands tucked into the sleeves of her jacket. Lance stood a little further away, his rucksack already resting against the stone wall.

Clair spoke first. Her voice was low, almost cautious.

'I've no objection to you going to Kanto… But what's really driving you? Ambition? The glory of Johto? That's not really in your nature.'

Lance didn't reply straight away. He lowered his gaze slightly to his hands, which he had clasped in front of him. His fingers clenched for a moment, then relaxed.

'That's not the point,' he murmured.

He paused for a longer moment. The wind rustled the tall grass at the edge of the terrace.

“You know that dragons are mythical creatures. Their superiority lies not only in their power. There is also longevity, harmony with nature… the core values of Johto. Here, our clan enjoys a privilege. And pre-eminence brings with it responsibilities. Just like the three beasts.”

He raised his head slightly, without really looking at Clair.

“If what we’re defending here is truly valuable… doesn’t keeping it only amongst ourselves ultimately make it more fragile? That’s what troubles me most.”

Clair fell silent for a moment. She turned her head slightly towards the mountains, as if searching for the right words. When she spoke again, her voice was a little lower, almost hesitant.

“You know I’m… rather conventional. Almost too much so, sometimes. So I’m not going to tell you that Kanto is wrong about everything. But… is the institution, the way they do things over there… is that really a solution? Or are we just in danger of losing our way along the way?”

She finally turned to face him. Her gaze was direct, but there was something fragile about the way she held her arms close to her side.

“You’re an excellent dragon master, my brother. But… are you really going to be all right? Will you be able to cope with everything that this will entail?”

Lance exhaled a soft sigh, almost a joyless laugh, and lowered his eyes again.

“You can’t even hide your traditional obstinacy …”

Clair did not take the dig to heart. She remained silent, waiting.

Lance finally spoke, his voice lower:

“…I know you’re worried. And I also know you’re not saying that to stop me. But I’ve already made up my mind.”

He looked up and met her gaze this time. His expression was calm, but weary.

“Whatever happens, I don’t want it to damage what we have. Even if I’m wrong.”

Clair slowly lowered her eyes to the stone floor. She didn’t reply straight away. The wind blew again, colder this time.

After a moment, she simply said, without looking up:

“Whatever you do… do it knowing that you don’t have to carry the burden alone.”

Lance didn’t reply. He merely nodded slightly, once. The silence that followed was long. Neither of them tried to break it.

In the distance, the last glimmers of twilight faded over the mountains.

End of scene

Scene – A Hollow Title

At the League ***(Kanto – Side corridor of Indigo Plateau, after a ceremony. Cold artificial light.) 1 min***

The corridor was long, silent, lit by wall sconces spaced too far apart. The white marble walls reflected a harsh, flat light. In the distance, the muffled applause from the main hall could still be heard, already dying away.

Lance walked alone. His Elite Four coat was immaculate, his hair carefully slicked back. He had the bearing one would expect of him: upright, calm, almost imposing. But his steps were a little too measured, as if he were controlling every movement.

He stopped in front of a large window overlooking the mountains. Outside, the sky was already dark. He placed a hand on the cold pane. His fingers remained still for a moment, then clenched slightly against the glass.

Behind him, the last echoes of the applause died away completely. Silence returned, heavier than the noise.

BGM 'EP02 S01 15:30–16:06'

Lance didn't move straight away. His reflection in the glass was clear, almost perfect. But his eyes remained fixed on something in the distance, or perhaps on nothing at all. He breathed in slowly, as if trying to fill his lungs with air that wasn't really coming.

After a moment, he let his hand fall by his side. He mechanically adjusted the collar of his coat, a precise, almost automatic gesture. Then he set off again, his back still straight, towards the end of the corridor where another meeting was already waiting for him.

The light from the wall lamps glinted off his uniform without really illuminating it.

End of scene

Scene – The acerbic announcement

Lance's office at the Pokémon League. Daylight, following Lance's defeat.

The room was austere, almost devoid of any personal touches. The walls were pale, the furniture functional. A large window looked out onto the League's gardens, where the light fell evenly, without any particular warmth. Lance stood near his desk, still in his Elite Four uniform. His shoulders were straight, but one could sense a restrained tension in the line of his back, as if he were struggling not to let an older burden show.

Red stood facing him, a few paces away. He was still breathing a little heavily after the battle, but his face remained calm. Lance looked at him for a moment, then spoke in a measured voice:

"You are now the Pokémon League Champion."

Red did not reply straight away. A very slight sense of relief flashed across his eyes, but it faded almost immediately. He looked down at the ground briefly, before raising his eyes again. His hands, which hung by his sides, clenched ever so slightly.

Lance noticed these details. He continued, in a slightly lower voice:

“Well… not quite.”

Red stood motionless. Only a very slight tightening of his jaw gave anything away. His expression did not visibly change, but his gaze lingered for a moment on an undefined point behind Lance, as if he needed a moment to take in the information. His breathing, which had returned to near normal, became a little more controlled.

Lance watched him in silence for a few seconds. He could see how Red was trying to come to terms with what had just happened, and he could also see that he was only partly succeeding.

‘There is still one more trial ahead of you,’ he continued. ‘A great Trainer awaits you. His name is Green. He defeated the Elite Four before you did.’

BGM ‘Powerful Predatory Deadly’ 03:08–the end

Red barely moved. His shoulders remained straight. Only a very slight twitch appeared at the corners of his eyes, and his fingers clenched a little tighter against his palms. He made no attempt to reply. He simply stared at Lance, his face once again almost neutral, but with a heavier look in his eyes.

Lance held his gaze for a moment. He made no attempt to soften his words. He simply stood there, his hands clasped in front of him, his fingers slightly clenched, with a subtle, diffuse air of contrition in the line of his shoulders. As if he regretted having had to utter those words, yet was unable to hold them back.

Red finally nodded very slowly, just once. He said nothing. Neither did Lance. Silence settled between them, broken only by the distant, muffled sounds from the corridors of the League.

End of scene

Scene – The Painful Birth of a Champion

League hearing room. Daylight, slightly subdued

BGM ‘Family in Heart’

The large hall had fallen very quiet. Red was still standing, but his body betrayed a deep weariness. Charizard, kneeling beside him, was trembling slightly, its wings half-folded. Scars from burns and blows marked its flank. Red was breathing steadily, but one could sense he was struggling to maintain an upright posture.
Green had already left the hall. He had not stormed out in a fit of rage or in a loud refusal to accept his defeat. He had simply withdrawn, rather quickly, as if remaining in that space had become unbearable for him. It was not pride that had driven him out, but rather the sudden inability to face what Red had just brought to light.

Lance stood a little way back, near the railing. He watched Red without saying a word. His gaze was fixed, more intense than usual. He wasn’t just looking at the new champion. He was watching the way Red was trying to contain something else — something that had nothing to do with victory.

Red lowered his eyes very slightly towards the floor. It was an almost imperceptible movement, lasting just a fraction of a second. His fingers, which had been hanging by his sides, slowly clenched

into fists, then relaxed. He looked up again immediately afterwards, as if he'd pulled himself together. His expression remained neutral, almost blank. Only a very slight twitch at the corner of his jaw betrayed that he was struggling to come to terms with what he'd just heard.

Lance didn't take his eyes off Red. He'd seen that brief moment of inner turmoil. He'd also seen the way Red had immediately pulled himself together, as if refusing to let anything show. That self-control suddenly struck him as a heavy burden. Too heavy for someone who'd only just won the Championship title.

The silence dragged on.

No one in the stands moved. Blue was frozen. Her hands were clenched on her knees, her face pale. She couldn't bring herself to stand up. The members of the Elite Four remained silent. Not even Agatha and Lorelei offered a comment. Professor Oak stood near the edge of the pitch. He stared at Red, his mouth slightly open, but he could not bring himself to utter the congratulations he ought to have offered. His hands were clasped in front of him, his fingers clenched so tightly that his knuckles had turned white. He seemed lost in thought, as if something older and heavier had taken hold of him.
Lance finally spoke. His voice was calm, but a little lower than usual:

'You are now the Pokémon League Champion.'

Red didn't reply. He nodded very slightly, just once, without really looking up at Lance. His gaze remained fixed a little too intently on a spot on the floor.

Lance watched him for a long while longer. He saw the weariness weighing on Red's shoulders, the way Charizard was struggling to stay on its feet. He also saw that Red didn't really dare to give in to what he was feeling. Something about that restraint touched Lance more deeply than he would have liked.

Silence fell once more, even heavier than before.

No one stepped forward to help Red to his feet. No one applauded. Daylight continued to stream into the hall, bright and indifferent, whilst the new Champion stood in the centre, alone with his exhausted Pokémon.

Lance finally lowered his gaze. His fingers clenched slightly against the edge of the balustrade. He said nothing more.

End of scene

Scene – You Won't Regret It

Corridors of the Pokémon League, late afternoon. The light is beginning to fade

Daylight had almost completely faded. Only a few wall lamps dimly lit the office. Several documents were still spread out on the desk. Red had completed the final formalities. He put the pen away carefully, almost too slowly, then stood for a moment with his hands resting on the desk. He didn't turn round straight away. His shoulders had slumped slightly, and he was staring at the corner of the desk as if he were still looking for a reason to linger.

Lance was waiting for him a little further down the corridor, standing motionless.

BGM ‘EP01 S02 19:53–20:33’

Red finally straightened up. He walked past Lance without looking up straight away. He stopped a few paces away from him, his bag slung over his shoulder. He opened his mouth, then closed it again. His fingers tightened around the strap of his bag. He lowered his head slightly, his gaze fixed on the tiled floor.

Lance then spoke, in a calm, measured voice:

“I’ll make sure you don’t regret it.”

Red slowly raised his head. He looked at Lance for a moment. Lance held his gaze without trying to smile. There was a kind of quiet, almost serious gravity in his eyes. Red nodded very slightly, just once. It was a discreet, almost shy gesture.

He stood there motionless for a few more seconds, as if he were still hesitating to leave. His fingers tightened around the strap one last time, then relaxed. At last, he turned on his heel.

Lance watched him go.

Red walked at a steady pace, but you could sense he was holding something back. He didn’t look back. Yet, just before turning the corner of the corridor, he slowed down ever so slightly, almost imperceptibly, before disappearing.

Lance didn’t take his eyes off the spot where Red had vanished. His gaze remained fixed on the emptiness of the corridor, longer than necessary. He didn’t move. His hands were still in his coat pockets, but his shoulders had tensed slightly. He stood there, silent, staring at the deserted corridor as if Red might still reappear.

The light continued to fade gently from the walls.

End of scene

Scene – Election Anxiety

Corridors of the Pokémon League, late afternoon.

Green emerged from his final interviews without hurrying. He packed his documents into his bag with slow, almost mechanical movements. The corridor was already quieter. The other Gym Leaders had scattered in small groups, speaking in hushed tones.

He took a few steps, then stopped.

Two of them were chatting a little further on, without having noticed him. He didn't catch everything, but he got the gist: opinions were very divided. Almost evenly split. He didn't need it confirmed. He already knew. His past still weighed too heavily. He'd read it in the silences, in the overly polite glances, in the way some had listened to him without really believing him.

He clenched his jaw.

BGM 'She Who Mauls' 02:12–02:38

Misty was the only one whose stance remained truly decisive. The others had already chosen their side, or were leaning towards one. Not her. And she had every reason not to want to see him at the helm of Viridian.

Green stood motionless for a moment, his gaze fixed on the floor. He did **not** feel like going over to speak to her. The very idea of having to explain himself, of having to justify anything, was deeply unpleasant to him. It felt too much like an attempt to exonerate himself, and he hated the impression that gave. He didn't want to appear to be trying to redeem himself in a showy way.

Yet he knew this: if he wanted his commitment to have any real meaning, and not just be an empty institutional formality, he could not avoid this conversation. Especially not with her.

He slowly raised his head. His expression was impassive. He did not move straight away. He stood there, in the emptying corridor, his shoulders slightly tense, as if he were still weighing up the possibility of escaping it.

There was no other way out.

End of scene

Scene – I'm waiting for your challenge

Side corridor of the League, after the preliminary interviews. The light is already fading

Green approached her in the corridor. At first he walked a little too quickly, then slowed down noticeably when he was a few paces away. Misty was standing by a window, her arms crossed. She didn't turn round straight away.

He stopped at a respectful distance. His voice came out lower than he'd intended.

'…I need to talk to you.'

Misty kept her eyes on the window for a moment longer before turning round. Her face was calm, but impassive.

"If you want to convince me, I'm not really sure… neither do I."

A silence fell. Green lowered his gaze slightly towards the ground. He clenched his jaw once before speaking again.

"I didn't mean to do it in such a… showy way."

Misty looked at him then. She didn't blink.

"I don't like holding a grudge. But forgetting that Red's disappearance is also your doing… that's not so easy for me. Sorry I'm not generous enough."

Green made no attempt to defend himself. He remained silent for a moment, his shoulders slightly tense.

"Regret alone is not enough," he said at last. "Neither to set things right, nor to bring Red back."

He paused. His voice was deeper, more restrained.

"Viridian… that's where Red was injured. The strongest Gym Leader betrayed us. If being the strongest can be redefined… if it can serve to protect the dignity of other Trainers, then perhaps I can still be of use. So that others are no longer humiliated in the same place."

Misty remained silent. She was now looking at him directly, but without giving anything away too clearly.

"…I understand that you want to make amends," she said after a moment. "But going that far is excessive self-sacrifice. Even if it's sincere."

Green nodded very slightly. He made no attempt to contradict her.

BGM "EP03 S02 16:50–17:30"

"I'm also doing this because I want Red to be able to come back one day… to a society that deserves him."

That sentence seemed to carry more weight than the previous ones. Misty looked down for a moment. When she looked up again, her expression was even more weary.

Green took a step back, ready to leave.

'I'm sorry for defeating you in such a… less than proper manner.'

He took another step, his gaze already fixed on the end of the corridor.

Misty spoke before he had actually walked away.

"You'll still be able to win in a more honourable way."

Green halted. He turned halfway round, surprised.

"Huh?… Shall I challenge you as soon as I become a Gym Leader…?"

Misty looked at him for a moment. She wasn't smiling, but there was no longer any overt coldness in her tone.

"A Gym Leader is also eligible to challenge me."

She said nothing more. She turned on her heel and walked away down the corridor, without looking back.

Green stood alone for a moment, his gaze fixed on the spot where she had disappeared. He did not yet know whether this was an opening or mere politeness. But for the first time since the start of the day, he did not feel completely rejected.

End of scene

Scene – The Wavering Favour

Voting room. Subdued lighting, late afternoon

BGM: the remainder of 'EP03 S02 16:50–17:30'

The counting of the votes was quick and silent. No one spoke. Green stood with his hands buried in his coat pockets, his shoulders slightly slumped. He stared at the floor, as if avoiding eye contact with the other Gym Leaders.

When the result was announced, a brief murmur rippled through the room. He had been elected. By a narrow margin.

Green slowly raised his head. His expression remained serious, almost impassive. There was no visible relief on his face. Only a kind of restrained weariness, as if this victory were already weighing heavily on him.

He then turned his gaze towards Misty, who was standing a little apart, near a column.

She was already looking at him.

Their eyes met. Green held her gaze for a second, then looked away almost immediately, as if he'd been taken aback by what he'd seen there. He lowered his eyes slightly, clenched his jaw once, and pushed his hands deeper into his pockets. There was no triumph in his demeanour. Rather, there was a subtle, almost childlike awkwardness, as if he didn't know how to take this vote.

Misty did not look away straight away. Her face was calm, almost neutral. She had voted in his favour; of that there was no doubt. But in her gaze lingered a quiet melancholy, mingled with an uncertainty that had not yet dissipated. As if she were giving him a chance, whilst still wondering whether it was the right decision.

Green looked up briefly a second time. Their eyes met once more. This time, he didn't hold her gaze. He turned his head away, staring at some undefined point on the wall behind her. His shoulders were slightly more tense than before.

Misty nodded very slightly, just once, almost imperceptibly. It was neither an outright encouragement nor a warm approval. Just a polite, almost distant gesture. She then turned away to speak to another Gym Leader, without saying another word to him.

Green remained motionless for a moment longer, his gaze fixed on the floor. He didn't seem relieved. Rather, he looked like a man who had just been given something he didn't yet know how to handle.

End of scene

Scene – Misunderstanding. Paradoxical statement

Pallet Town, late in the evening. A small square on high ground overlooking the rooftops, near Professor Oak's house. The wind is cold.

Green approached without really knowing how to begin. He slowed noticeably halfway there, as if still hesitating, then stopped a little too far away. He kept his hands buried in his pockets, his gaze downcast.

Blue was standing by the low wall, her arms crossed. She didn't turn round straight away.

Blue finally spoke, in a low voice:

'…Congratulations.'

Blue turned round slowly. She opened her mouth, but no sound came out straight away. She seemed to need to gather her strength before replying.

"…Thank you," Green said at last. Her voice was weak, almost breathless.

Silence fell. Green stared at the ground between them. Blue kept her arms clasped tightly against her, as if she were cold. When she spoke again, her voice was a little lower:

"Viridian Gym… What an unpleasant memory."

Green lifted his head slightly. He looked at her for a moment before replying, in a calm but cautious tone:

"Your sadness is understandable. I know full well that it's Red you care about…"

Blue turned abruptly towards him. She opened her mouth, but the words didn't come out straight away. You could tell from the tension in her jaw and the slight tremor in her breath that she was struggling to speak. When she finally managed it, her voice was strained, almost choked:

"I forbid you to say anything foolish."

She fell silent straight away, as if speaking had taken a toll on her. She lowered her eyes, pulled her arms a little tighter around herself, and breathed more heavily, as if to regain her composure.

Green looked down again. He remained silent for a moment, then asked, almost reluctantly:

"What? Am I mistaken?"

Blue didn't reply straight away. She seemed to be gathering her strength. When she spoke, her voice was lower, but it was clear she was struggling to articulate:

'Being your childhood friend… doesn't mean I can see all your problems. Sometimes it actually stops me from doing so.'

She paused again, as if catching her breath. Green looked up.

"So why did you step in on his behalf during our fight? By cheering him on so… openly."

BGM "EP03 S01 23:40–24:17"

Blue closed her eyes briefly. When she opened them again, she was staring at a spot on the floor. She began to speak, paused, then started again, her voice sounding more strained:

"I couldn't… set you straight myself. I'm not even skilled enough in combat for that. So I could only speak to Red. I couldn't help you… without hurting you. Or without fuelling your stupid jealousy. I was… so ashamed."

She stopped there, slightly out of breath. You could tell from the way she was clutching her arms to her side that she was struggling to stay on her feet. She lowered her head, as if those last words had drained her.

Green stood motionless; he was no longer trying to look at her directly.

Green finally spoke, in a lower, almost resigned voice:

“You and Red, you’re both willing to sacrifice yourselves for anyone,” he said at last. “Even for a scoundrel…”

Blue slowly looked up at him. Her expression was weary, almost resigned.

“I did care. Fortunately, as your childhood friend, I can still see something positive left in you. I have no regrets.”

She said nothing more. She turned away slightly, her gaze fixed on the distant lights, her arms still clasped tightly around herself. It was clear she was struggling to breathe normally, as if speaking had truly taken its toll on her.

Green did not reply. He kept his eyes downcast, his hands buried deep in his pockets. Neither of them made any move to break the silence.

End of scene

Scene – Would you have wanted it to be him?

Professor Oak’s laboratory, one to two years after Green’s election. Daylight, slightly cold

BGM ‘EP01 S02 25:40–27:00’

The laboratory was quieter than usual. Documents and samples were still scattered across the tables, but the atmosphere lacked its usual energy. Green stood by a table, his hands in his coat pockets. Oak had offered him a small cake, placed on a plate beside him. Green had barely touched it.

Professor Oak was fidgeting aimlessly with a few test tubes, as if trying to keep his hands busy. He finally stopped, his shoulders slightly slumped.

‘You’ve done well over the last few years,’ he said at last. ‘Viridian has changed. It’s… commendable.’

Green kept his eyes fixed on the cake.

“I’ll take it,” he replied in a low voice. “Even though I don’t really want it. And I could do without it.”

Silence fell. Oak did not attempt to break it at once. He regarded Green with an expression that was hard to read—at once proud and weary.

Green finally looked up. His voice was more strained:

“You’d have preferred it to be Red, wouldn’t you?”

Oak didn’t reply straight away. He kept his eyes fixed on the table, his fingers clenching slightly against the wood. He’d understood. Not just the question itself, but what lay beneath it: Green wasn’t really

looking for a blunt answer. He was testing something else. Oak knew this, and it made the situation harder to handle.

He took a slow breath before replying, in a voice lower than usual:

'…The basis of this question?' he asked, in a lower voice.

Green clenched his jaw.

"Have you never had that sort of thought? Not even once?"

Oak closed his eyes briefly. He had grasped the true meaning of the question: Green wasn't expecting a frank confession. He was trying to find out whether his grandfather was capable of answering him without causing him further harm. This realisation made the answer even more difficult to formulate. Oak remained silent for a long while. He seemed to be searching for an answer that was neither a lie nor too direct a blow. When he spoke, his voice was cautious, almost awkward:

'No. I sent Red on the journey at the same time as you because I had a feeling you'd need someone like him. And my intuition didn't let me down on that point.'

Green looked down again. That answer did not seem to have put his mind at rest. Quite the opposite. He stopped there. He knew his answer was not enough, but he could not find the words to say more without causing hurt. He looked down at his own hands, his fingers still clenched against the edge of the table.

Green remained silent for a moment. He could tell that Oak had understood his intention, and yet the reply remained evasive. That did nothing to reassure him. Quite the opposite.

'You're right… But you don't have to lie to me,' he said at last, in an even quieter voice. 'I already know you've had those kinds of thoughts. I'm not asking you to confess everything. Just… not to pretend it doesn't exist.'

Oak closed his eyes briefly. He took a slow breath, as if weighing every word.

'…When you become a parent yourself, you'll understand that we're all subject to certain limits imposed by blood. I suppose.'

His voice lacked conviction. He himself seemed dissatisfied with his own reply. He turned slightly, avoiding Green's gaze.

"At least you've shown that Red's efforts weren't entirely in vain. Even if… it probably cost more than it should have."

The silence that followed was heavy. Green stared at the cake without really seeing it. Oak kept his hands resting on the table, his fingers slightly clenched. Neither of them made any move to continue the conversation. The weight of what had been left unsaid hung between them.

Oak finally spoke again in a softer, almost resigned voice:

"You did what you could. That's already a lot."

Green did not reply. He nodded very slightly, half-heartedly, then turned away slightly, his gaze lost on the laboratory shelves.

Oak remained silent. He gripped the edge of the table a little tighter. He'd have liked to find a reply that was both honest and protective, but he felt he couldn't manage it. He simply stayed there, his

eyes downcast, his shoulders slumped slightly.

End of scene

Scene – Warrior, scientist and politician

League Hall, shortly after Green's election. Daylight, somewhat cold.

Lance stood by a window, his arms crossed. Green had remained in the room after the others had left, as if he were waiting for something. The silence lasted a moment before Lance spoke, in a direct but calm tone:

'I don't follow you. Why aren't you the one taking on the role of Champion?'

Green lowered his gaze slightly towards the floor. It took him a moment to reply, as if he were searching for the right words without wanting to say too much.

"It's not a question of ability… at least, not just in combat."

Lance raised an eyebrow slightly, clearly surprised by the answer. Green continued, a little more slowly, with a hint of awkwardness in his tone:

"Recently, I've realised that everyone has their own speciality. I'm still too young to handle international affairs between Kanto and Johto. It's not my area of expertise."
Lance raised an eyebrow slightly, clearly surprised.

"How unusual. Usually, people strive to climb as high as possible."
Green lowered his eyes to the table once more.

"I admire those who travel and deal with such matters. Or at least, I pretend to. But it's not really in my nature. Someone close to me was right… I'm not cut out for that sort of thing. Too unstable, perhaps."

He paused, then added, almost as if justifying himself:

"I can teach what I know, as a Gym Leader and a researcher. It's a balance that suits me better. And suits others better, I think."

Lance looked at him for a moment without saying a word. At first, he'd thought Green was turning down the post out of excessive modesty, or for fear of taking on too much responsibility. But as he listened, he gradually realised that this wasn't an attempt to run away. Green was simply defining what it meant to 'be the strongest' in a different way.

BGM "EP01 S01 08:00–08:16"

Green looked up at him slightly, without arrogance, but with a kind of quiet conviction:

'It's not out of weakness. I'd rather hand this responsibility over to someone better suited to bear it. You're more involved in international affairs than I am. I'm not mistaken, am I?'

Lance remained silent for a moment. His expression shifted slightly. At first, he'd thought Green was trying to shirk the task, or that he lacked ambition. But as he listened, he realised it was neither of those things. Green was simply stating a fact, without seeking to belittle himself or to flatter.

Lance slowly uncrossed his arms. His gaze had become more composed, almost pensive. He did not reply straight away. He simply watched Green, as if he were re-evaluating what he had just heard.

Green made no attempt to fill the silence. He stood there, hands in his pockets, waiting without pressing the matter.

Lance finally nodded very slightly, just once. It wasn't a polite nod of agreement, but a sign of understanding. He said nothing more. He no longer needed to argue his point.

Green saw this. He did not smile, but something in his posture relaxed ever so slightly. He knew that Lance had understood.

End of scene

The reform of the Elite Four

The League's deliberation chamber. Twilight

Background music: 'Rebellion' (up to 02:24)

The large room was bathed in low-angled light. Shadows stretched across the walls. Lance stood by the window, arms crossed, gazing at the building's façade. He stood motionless. He seemed simply to be observing the building, as if searching for something he had not yet seen.

Agatha, Lorelei and Bruno were already there. They waited in silence. Lance finally turned round. He spoke in a calm voice, without trying to persuade them:

'I think we need to broaden our criteria. Combat prowess remains important, but it isn't everything. We must also embody something else. It's time to make way for the next generations.'

Silence fell. Agatha was the first to react. She placed her hand flat on the table.

"As for me, I'm stepping down."

Lorelei and Bruno looked up, surprised. Agatha had never been the sort to give up easily.

BGM 'Rebellion' 01:13–02:23

She continued, in a slightly lower voice:

"It's not because I've grown too old. My spirit remains strong. But my Pokémon are old. Older than yours. I do not wish to force them to continue merely for the sake of my pride. And besides… old Oak is growing lonely as he ages. I owe him that much."

Lorelei spoke after a moment's silence. Her voice was cold, yet tense:

"I, too, am stepping aside. Not because I've become incompetent. It's simply that… the new generation doesn't need someone as cold as me."

Bruno remained silent for a little longer. He looked at his hands, resting on his knees. When he spoke, his voice was deep, without any aggression:

"As for me, I'm staying."

Lance looked at him, waiting for him to continue.

Bruno shrugged slightly.

“Some values may seem old-fashioned, harsh, outdated. But they still have their place. Discipline, perseverance… they can still serve as an example to young people. I’m not here to cling on. I’m here because I can still be of use in this way.”

Silence followed. Lance slowly lowered his eyes to the floor. He remained like that for a moment, his arms still crossed. Then he raised his head and looked at Bruno. His expression had changed. The tension had gone from his shoulders. He nodded once, clearly, without exaggeration, but with a decisiveness that had not been there before.

He did not smile. He simply said, in a low, sincere voice:

‘…I’m glad you’re staying.’

Bruno didn’t reply. He simply nodded back, just once. Agatha was the first to stand up, unhurriedly. Lorelei followed her. Bruno remained seated for a moment longer before standing up himself.

Lance watched them leave without saying another word. When the door closed, he was left alone in the room. He turned towards the window and placed a hand on the stone sill. His fingers clenched slightly against the edge, then relaxed. He remained like that for a moment, his gaze fixed on the building’s façade, his shoulders slightly less tense than before.

End of scene

Scene – The Ascent (visual interlude)

The League

BGM: ‘Rebellion’ (from ~01:14–02:24, up to 02:24)

Twilight streams in at an angle through the League’s tall windows. Golden and bluish rays glide across the worn floors, highlighting the fine cracks running through the marble and the cobwebs clinging to the corners of the mouldings. The air is heavy, almost still, laden with fine dust that dances slowly in the fading light. One senses the weight of a change that does not shout, but is taking hold.

Will stands upright, slightly ahead of the other two. His violet hair catches the last of the light. His purple suit, austere and perfectly tailored, contrasts sharply with the hall’s faded grandeur. His expression is calm, almost detached. His eyes, however, are not: they observe with quiet precision, as though he had already seen many worlds and retained from each what was useful. With a slow, precise gesture, he adjusts the white knot of his tie. The movement is elegant, without ostentation. His hands fall naturally by his sides. He does not smile. He is simply there, like a presence that accepts its role without turning it into a triumph.

To his right, Koga stands in fluid balance. His traditional attire is understated, almost austere, yet nothing about him seems rigid. His weight is distributed with almost imperceptible precision, ready to move at any moment without ever stiffening. His gaze is patient, fixed on the ground before him rather than on the others. He does not move much. A slight shift of the shoulder, a slow blink of the eyelids. This is the full extent of the restrained agility of a man who has learnt that true precision is not for show.

Standing slightly to one side, Karin remains perfectly still. Her face is serene, almost gentle in the fading light. Nothing in her demeanour betrays any severity or aloofness. There is even, in the way she holds her hands clasped in front of her, something almost protective. Her gaze, on the other hand, is harder to read. There is depth to it, and something still hidden. She observes Will and Koga without judgement, simply taking in the new arrangement. She does not seek to draw attention to herself. She is there, and one senses she will remain so, quietly.

The three do not look directly at one another. They do not speak. They simply occupy the space that Agatha and Lorelei have just left. The music continues to play whilst the lights continue to dim. For a few seconds, they are the only ones visible in this twilight hall, as if time had chosen this precise moment to mark the transition.

End of visual interlude – fade to the next scene

Scene – The lengthening shadow

BGM: 'Rebellion' (from 02:25, more subdued tone)

Professor Oak's voice echoed faintly through the telephone. He had been speaking for several minutes already, in a measured but slightly troubled voice.

"…It wasn't the same as before. They didn't try to impress. They acted in a very direct way, almost… efficient. As if they already knew what they wanted to achieve."

On the other side, Lance remained silent for a moment. He was standing by the window in the League hall, gazing at the sky, which was beginning to darken. When he replied, his voice was low and a little disjointed.

'…Did you see how they retreated?'

Oak hesitated slightly before replying.

"Yes. Without trying to push it. As if they didn't need to stay any longer."

Lance looked down. He gripped the phone a little tighter, then let go.

"…That's not like Giovanni."

He said nothing more. The sentence hung in the air, as if he hadn't wanted to go any further.

Oak did not pick up on it straight away. After a moment, he continued in a more cautious tone:

"Lance… if you're thinking of doing something, just tell me straight."

Lance didn't reply straight away. He turned his head slightly towards the window, as if gazing at the horizon.

"…A young man who finds himself facing that. Alone."

His voice remained halting, almost as if he were thinking out loud. He didn't explain what he meant by 'that'. He let the silence do the rest.

Oak seemed to be weighing his words.

“Do you think it’s already starting to take shape?”

Lance didn’t reply straight away. He stared at a point in front of him, his brow slightly furrowed. When he spoke again, it was in a lower voice, almost as if to himself:

“…I don’t yet know what they’re capable of. Not really.”

He hung up without offering any further explanation.

Change of scene – Lake of Rage

The lake’s surface had returned to a state of calm, but traces of the recent battle were still visible: patches of murky water, reeds bent over on the bank, and in places, the earth still bore the marks of a violent upheaval.

Lance was standing not far from the water. At times, the wind stirred up small ripples that came to rest against the battered banks. Above him, the clouds were slowly gathering, heavy and grey.

He had not called Oak back. The phone had remained in his hand for a moment, then he had slipped it into his pocket. He was observing the lake without really looking at it, his gaze somewhat lost in the distance.

From time to time, he would squint slightly, as if trying to see something that was not there yet. His expression was not tense, but rather absorbed, almost as if he were already working something out without being fully aware of it yet.

He stood motionless for a long time, whilst the wind gently rippled the surface of the water.

End of scene

(Lance does not make any clear decision. However, his demeanour suggests that he has already begun to take a stance internally, even if he has not yet fully realised it.)

Scene – An obscene disguise

Mahogany Town’s lair

The large underground hall of the Mahogany Town lair was dimly lit by yellowish industrial lamps. The air was heavy, laden with the smell of damp concrete, cold metal and stale sweat. A low platform had been erected at the back. In front of it, the grunts were gathered in irregular ranks. A few scientists stood further back, even more motionless.

Lambda stood on the platform, already disguised as Giovanni. From a distance, the resemblance was sufficient. Up close, it was unsettling. The face was too stiff, the features too sharp. The coat draped correctly over his shoulders, but the way he held his head lacked the natural heaviness of the original. He was not trying to embody Giovanni. He was merely **taking his place**, as one assumes a role whose limitations are already known.

He slowly raised a hand, palm open, in a sweeping yet mechanical gesture. The movement was a little too sweeping, a little too solemn. There was no warmth in the gaze he cast over the assembly. Just a kind of sombre, restrained satisfaction.

Below, the grunts showed no visible enthusiasm. Yet a kind of collective tension seemed to dissipate. Several of them exhaled more deeply, almost simultaneously. Their shoulders slumped slightly. Their gazes fixed on Lambda with a stark, almost voracious intensity. It was as if they **were drawing in** the permission contained in that crude gesture. Not admiration. A kind of eager relief, as if the mere sight of this counterfeit allowed them to release a restraint they usually held back.

BGM: 'Fire It Is' (from 01:39)

In the high, dim light of the hall, **Murkrow** was already there. It stood perfectly still on a beam, its red eyes glimmering faintly in the darkness. It watched without a single superfluous movement: insidious, clinical, patient. It seemed neither interested nor amused. It **was keeping watch**.

Lambda slowly clenched his hand into a fist. The movement was heavy, almost laborious. Several grunts reacted in unison by leaning back ever so slightly, imperceptible to anyone not watching closely. Their breathing seemed to have grown a little heavier. The atmosphere became denser, more opaque, as if the latent violence in the room had just found a foothold.

Lambda tilted his head slightly. The movement was slow, almost affectionate. At that moment, the atmosphere in the room seemed to grow heavier. The grunts's malice had not been stirred by fervour. It had **been fuelled**. They knew, vaguely or instinctively, that this was not the real Giovanni. They also knew that it no longer really mattered. This pretence was enough for them to feel authorised once more to vandalise, to inflict harm, to take without too many immediate consequences.

The grunts stood motionless. But in their eyes, something more raw, more ancient, had multiplied. A symbiotic, almost parasitic malice—it was not aroused. It was fuelled, as if the counterfeit were providing them with a substance they needed to feel fully authorised.

Not a word was spoken. Only that collective breathing—slightly heavier, slightly more synchronised—broke the silence. The grunts stood motionless, but something ancient and ravenous had awakened within them, and now seemed to be feasting on this charade.

Then, in the silence, a voice rang out. It sounded like Lambda's: hoarse, slightly strained.

'Long live… Master Giovanni.'

The cry was not powerful. It was almost mechanical. Lambda had not opened his mouth. Murkrow, in the shadows, had not moved either. Only his red eyes continued to stare at the room without blinking.

End of scene

Scene – The Moving Manhunt

Mahogany Town, an autumn night

BGM 'EP05 S02 11:46–13:00'

Mahogany Town lay cloaked in cold darkness. Autumn had already stripped most of the trees bare, and the wind that rattled the alleyways carried the scent of fallen leaves and damp earth. Streetlamps cast circles of yellowish light that failed to dispel the thick shadows clinging to the building facades.

An Ekans burst out and lunged forward, mouth wide open. Gold/Richter did not even slow down. With a sharp flick of his wrist, he cracked his hunting crop. The Pokémon was violently thrown against a brick wall and fell back to the ground, motionless.

BGM 'EP05 S02 11:46–13:00' from 00:05

Lance and Gold/Richter pressed on, silent and swift. Ahead, several grunts were retreating in disarray. One of them, seized by panic, threw a Poké Ball. More grunts appeared from the corner of an alleyway: a Drowzee, two Rattata, an Ariados and a Zubat. They did not all attack at once. They seemed to hesitate, as if they were still trying to cover their comrades' retreat.

Aerodactyl hovered low above them, its membranous wings slicing through the air with almost surgical precision. When Ariados, in a desperate move, fired a Night Shade at Lance, the prehistoric Pokémon shifted its angle slightly. It dodged the attack with a sharp flap of its wings, then dived. Aerial Ace struck the Ariados head-on. The blow was not excessive, yet it sufficed. Ariados was hurled to the ground, its legs trembling, unable to rise.

The grunts exchanged glances. One of them, his voice choked with emotion, recalled his Pokémon. Another hastily recalled his Drowzee. Just as the Pokémon was beginning to vanish into its Poké Ball, Scyther leapt forward. Pursuit. The blow, amplified by the attempt to recall it, struck the Drowzee with full force. The Pokémon collapsed without a sound.

The grunts did not press their advantage. They retreated in a rush, recalling their remaining Pokémon in a panic. Lance and Gold/Richter gave chase for a few dozen metres, but the grunts eventually vanished into the dark alleyways, taking advantage of the cover of night.

They halted. Gold/Richter drew in air, his gaze sweeping the area. Lance, meanwhile, was already examining the ground.

"They didn't have time to cover their tracks," he murmured.

A little further on, in a narrow alley lined with old warehouses, they spotted a metal door whose lock had been forced open. The marks were fresh. Someone had already been there, and not long ago.

Without a word, they went inside.

Team Rocket HQ, Mahogany Town

BGM "EP05 S02 11:46–13:00" from 00:20

The interior of the hideout was lit by pale neon lights that flickered intermittently. The air felt heavier, laden with the smell of cold metal and damp. On the walls, several Persian-shaped cameras were damaged—some torn from their mounts, others simply smashed. The footprints on the floor were still clear.

They moved forward cautiously until they found a control room. The room was empty, but the screens were still on. Lance approached a table on which several files were spread out. He leafed through them quickly, his eyes narrowed.

Gold/Richter, for his part, sat down at one of the computers and scrolled through the recordings from the last few hours.

Lance paused at one page. He read aloud in a low voice, almost to himself:

'…The access code works exclusively for the voice of a certain executive…'

He looked up, his brow slightly furrowed. This detail was significant. Someone had gone to the trouble of restricting access to a single voice.

Behind him, Gold/Richter had frozen in front of the screen. He had moved the cursor back slightly. On the screen, a familiar figure was making its way through the corridors of the hideout, swiftly, almost nonchalantly.

"The intruder is Silver," he said in a low but tense voice.

Lance turned round. Gold/Richter hadn't taken his eyes off the screen.

'He must have arrived just before us. If we let him carry on, he'll make everything more complicated.'

He stood up, his expression hardening.

"We must reach him before he does something foolish."

Team Rocket HQ, Mahogany Town

They left the monitoring room. Gold/Richter quietly released Haunter, who vanished almost immediately into the shadows of the ceiling, his red eyes glowing faintly.

BGM "EP05 S02 11:46–13:00" from 00:59

They had not gone ten metres when they heard footsteps. Two scientists appeared from around a corner in the corridor, accompanied by Magnemite. They seemed surprised to see them there, but reacted quickly. One of the Magnemite emitted a high-pitched buzz and fired an electric shock in their direction. Lance narrowly dodged it.

Aerodactyl reacted even before Lance had given a command. It swooped down on the first Magnemite and clamped its jaws shut in a precise Fire Fang, without using excessive force. The Magnemite was hurled against the wall and fell to the floor, motionless.

Scyther dealt with the second one. Rock Smash struck with a sharp, violent blow. The impact echoed through the corridor.

The two scientists recoiled in panic. They had no time to issue any further orders. Haunter emerged from the shadows behind them, its eyes gleaming. A moment later, the two men slumped gently to the floor, fast asleep.

Silence fell once more.

Lance stood motionless for a moment, his gaze fixed on the unconscious scientists. He'd nearly been hit. It was nothing much, but it had been close enough for him to feel it.

Gold/Richter approached without a word. He unfastened his cane from his belt and held it out to him, the pommel facing forwards.

‘Just in case.’

His voice was calm, almost neutral, but his expression was serious. Lance looked at him for a moment, then took the cane. A faint smile flitted across his face, both grateful and slightly ironic.

“Thank you.”

Gold/Richter returned his smile—brief but sincere.

They stood there for a moment, in the middle of the corridor, with the two scientists asleep at their feet and the distant hum of the faulty neon lights. The autumn night seemed to have seeped right into the walls of the hideout.

End of scene

Scene – Visceral Antagonism

Team Rocket HQ, Mahogany Town

BGM: ‘EP05 S02 16:32–18:08’

The room they had entered was more spacious than the previous corridors. The neon lights hanging from the ceiling flickered intermittently, casting irregular shadows on the concrete walls. The air was heavy, laden with the smell of cold metal and ancient damp.

Lance and Gold/Richter came to a halt in the centre of the room. Ahead of them, half a dozen grunts and two scientists were already waiting, accompanied by their Pokémon. The atmosphere did not suggest an impromptu ambush. There was something ancient, ritualised, almost bestial about the way the grunts stood, beneath the façade of a human organisation.

Gold/Richter flung several Poké Balls with a sharp flick of the wrist, in the style of travelling Trainers. Fearow, Alakazam and Seadra burst out of them and immediately scattered across the room. Ampharos remained in reserve.

The battle began without warning.

Alakazam immediately spotted a Koffing that was about to inflate dangerously. Confusion struck before the Pokémon could initiate Self-Destruct. The Koffing was hurled against a wall and fell back down, dazed.

Ariados tried to approach from the shadows. Shadow Sneak materialised, ghostly and swift, despite the species’ natural slowness. Aerodactyl dodged it without undue haste, simply changing direction with surgical precision. It counter-attacked immediately with Aerial Ace.

Aerodactyl didn’t stop there. Without anyone giving any obvious command, it flew in a wide circle above the minions. One by one, the Pokémon capable of using sneaky moves — Golbat, Zubat, Arbok, Ekans, Magnemite — were hit by Taunt. It took their Trainers a moment to realise why their Pokémon were no longer using their usual tricks. That moment was enough for Aerodactyl to neutralise two more—Arbok and Golbat—with Ice Fang and Aerial Ace. Meanwhile, several Zubat, Magnemite and Ekans fled amidst the chaos and panic.

At that moment Fearow and Scyther sprang into action; Pursuit caught the Pokémon attempting to retreat, and the blows landed on the fleeing creatures were clean and violent.

Porygon tried to boost its speed with Agility, but Scyther was quicker. Rock Smash struck it full force before it had finished its move. The mechanical Pokémon was hurled to the ground, its system visibly damaged. It nevertheless tried to get back on its feet to use Recover, but Scyther's Quick Attack finished it off before it could heal itself.

A Raticate lunged at Lance, its fangs gleaming with Hyper Fang. Lance took a step back, narrowly dodging the attack. His coat was slightly scratched, but he remained unharmed. With a fluid movement, he brought his cane down on the Pokémon's flank at just the right moment. The blow was not decisive, yet it sufficed to unbalance the Raticate. A follow-up strike from one of Gold/Richter's Pokémon finished the task.

As the number of opponents still capable of fighting dwindled, Gold/Richter briefly changed his target. He brought his hunting crop down repeatedly on the belts of the remaining grunts, striking directly and violently. The Poké Balls were knocked to the ground. Lance, for his part, knocked one or two over with his cane as well, more out of opportunism than any coordinated effort. Seadra, standing back, used Twister to draw the fallen Poké Balls towards him, preventing them from being easily retrieved.

Meanwhile, Haunter drifted through the shadows on the ceiling. Several grunts slumped to the ground, falling asleep without realising what had happened to them. Others, struck by Confuse Ray, began to stagger, losing all coordination.

Soon, only one Grunt remained standing. He tried to flee towards a side door, but Haunter's Mean Look caught him. The Grunt froze, eyes wide, realising he could no longer escape. Gold/Richter approached and, with a measured backhand of his cane, struck him on the back of the head. The Grunt collapsed without a cry.

Silence fell over the room.

Lance caught his breath. He glanced around at the grunts and scientists who were either unconscious or incapacitated, then turned to Gold/Richter.

'Let's split up,' he said. 'I'll take care of the password.'

Gold/Richter nodded in agreement. They exchanged no further words. Each went their separate ways.

Superintendent's Office, Team Rocket HQ, Mahogany Town

Further into the depths of the lair, Silver made his way alone. He had bypassed several groups of distracted grunts and ventured into the less-frequented parts of the building. His face was tense, his pace brisk.

He eventually reached a door more imposing than the others. He cautiously pushed it ajar.

In the room beyond, a dim light illuminated a familiar figure. Lambda stood there, disguised as Giovanni. From a distance the imitation was passable, but something was awry in the details—the posture, the expression, the way he held his head. He was not alone. Perched on a beam or a tall piece of furniture, Murkrow watched him motionless, feigning indifference.

BGM: *'My* Sister' (01:54–02:07)

Silver paused on the threshold. The sight of this imposter seemed to strike him harder than he had anticipated. A wave of emotion — anger, shock, a confused desire for confrontation — welled up within him. His hands clenched. He took a step inside, as if he were about to expose himself.

In the shadows of an adjoining corridor, almost invisible in the dim light, a female figure stood motionless. Only her eyes were visible, cold and watchful. She observed the scene without intervening, without haste, like someone weighing up the various possible outcomes.

Within the room, Murkrow swivelled its head towards the shadow, then returned its gaze to Silver and Lambda, still without a superfluous movement.

Silver took a breath, ready to move forward.

It was then that a calm voice rang out behind him.

'Silver,' said Lance.

Lance was standing in the doorway, his cane in his hand. He, too, had followed the trail. His gaze shifted quickly from Silver to Lambda, then back to the young man.

The tension in the room remained palpable.

Murkrow, perched higher up, continued to watch in silence.

End of scene

Scene – Loooong live Master Giovanni!

Next: Superintendent's Office, Team Rocket HQ, Mahogany Town

BGM: 'Your Choice'

Images of the lair's dark corridors flashed by intermittently. Glimpses of the underground chambers, the captive Pokémon, the grunts standing guard. Then the gaze settled on the door to Lambda's room.

Lambda's room was plunged into a state of methodical disorder. Wigs, masks and baggy clothes littered the floor. Silver stood there, his gaze hard, whilst Lance (the Champion) looked down at him from his full height, his face impassive.

Silver clenched his teeth.

'So I don't need weak Pokémon…'

Lance stared at him for a long moment. His gaze was cold, almost jarring.

"You speak as if abandoning your Pokémon didn't matter at all. As if that would have allowed you to win."

Silver lowered his eyes slightly. A shadow of remorse flitted across his face, but he refused to let it show.

Lance turned away towards Lambda.

“So… can you give me the credential?”

Lambda swallowed hard. He was not afraid, but he felt he no longer had a choice. He opened his mouth and spoke in a slightly hoarse, vulgar voice:

“…You have to say in front of the…”

No sooner had he begun than the beak flew wide open. A shrill scream, **almost identical** to Lambda’s voice, pierced the air:

BGM: ‘Your Choice’ – 01:09

“Loooong live Master Giovanni!”

Lance and Silver were astonished that this voice comes from this Murkrow, and that it is capable of it, whilst Lambda was oblivious to the fact that Murkrow uttered this phrase on a whim. Murkrow gave the impression of having been infected by Lance’s interrogative rigidity. The Murkrow flew off abruptly… From time to time, it bumped into the edges of the walls, as if it had lost the structural integrity of a spontaneous movement.

‘Loooong live Master Giovanni!’ cried Murkrow.

The cry echoed through the corridors like a mad chant. Gold/Richter, who was making his way through the outer corridors, saw the black bird dart out. It was crashing into the walls, grazing faces, and seemed seized by hysterical panic. Yet, as it flew past him, their eyes met for a fraction of a second.
Gold/Richter pondered instinctively. *Had he uttered the password…?*

A frozen smile, all too aware. A living, cold mask, **watching**. There was no trace of genuine panic in its eyes — only acute, almost clinical attention, as if it were gauging the reaction it was provoking.

The Murkrow charged towards a reinforced door and continued to scream Giovanni’s name at the voice-recognition panel. A heavy click rang out. The door opened, but the rustle of the door opening was not that loud; Murkrow had intentionally muffled it with his opportunistic scream.

‘Loooong live Master Giovanni!’ cried Murkrow.

Just before reaching the room, the Murkrow released a black mist — *Haze* — dense enough to obscure the doorframe. The door would open in a moment. Gold/Richter, caught up in the screech and the low-level flight, was no longer in a position to see it.

Instead of entering the passageway, the Murkrow veered sharply into another corridor, whilst continuing to cry out. It was not trying to open that door. It was using it as a signal.

Gold/Richter realised this too late.

It was no coincidence. The Murkrow had deliberately led him **elsewhere**.

‘Your Choice’ – ~01:42

The Murkrow slowed down unhurriedly. It landed on Athena’s shoulder, suddenly perfectly still. Gone was the synthetic hysteria of the corridors — the thuds against the walls, the drawn-out scream. That silence was too sharp, too animalistic, to be anything but a sham.

Its gaze remained fixed on Gold/Richter. No agitation. Only a cold, precise focus, as if it were registering the tension it had itself just created.

The silence spread. It reached Gold/Richter and Fearow faster than a second scream. They tried to contain it — the trance, visceral, reined in. Fearow too stiff on his talons. Gold/Richter's fingers for a moment too tight on the hunting crop. It didn't quite hold.

Athena and a Grunt had already burst through a side door, ready for battle.

Gold/Richter read the bird's calm for a fraction of a second too long. Then the Raticate's fangs. Then the room. He realised too late that he'd been ambushed.

They had been lured into a Tag Battle, already at a disadvantage. The Grunt's Raticate was already out, its fangs gleaming.

Athena smiled slightly.

'What would you like me to do, Ms Athena?' asked the Grunt.

"We must extend our warmest welcome to our little lost rabbit, mustn't we?" replied Athena.

Gold/Richter hesitated for a second, then drew his hunting crop. Fearow, at his side, fidgeted violently.

"I understand your anxiety," he murmured. "I'm not trying to be a hero… But the circumstances don't allow me to command two Pokémon at the same time. At least let me fulfil my duty to protect my Pokémon… Trust me."

The battle began.

It was then that a Charizard suddenly emerged between the combatants, wings spread.

Gold/Richter jumped.

"Charizard?! Is that Red?"

A calm, almost courteous voice rang out behind him.

"Sorry not to be the real Red…"

Lance appeared, his face impassive.

"But I'll do my best."

Athena and the Grunt exchanged a brief glance. They feigned eagerness to win the battle, yet their attacks veered subtly off course, seeking to isolate Gold/Richter and Fearow.

Lance added in a low voice, without turning round:

"Be careful. You'll remain the main target. They'll likely aim for your Pokémon… or even you yourself. So don't hold back on attacking."

Gold/Richter hesitated for several seconds.

"What? I'm just supposed to attack?"

"Because I'll have cover you. Don't worry."

The battle grew fiercer, more relentless.

“Your Choice” – 02:38

Fearow and Raticate clashed in a brutal exchange. Murkrow, for its part, made no move to confront Charizard. It circled above the battlefield with chilling precision, diving at irregular intervals to harass Fearow or swoop directly down on Gold/Richter.

The Raticate charged relentlessly. It targeted Fearow — *Hyper Fang*, *Crunch* — or looked for an opening that would lead to the trainer. As soon as Charizard fired a *Flamethrower*, it would duck out of the way, then return with *a Sucker Punch* on Fearow — swift and treacherous — before retreating. Murkrow did the same: a clean *Wing Attack*, followed by an immediate ascent. In its eyes, a cold, almost satisfied glint.

They were not fighting out of fear or mere obedience; they pressed on because they wished to harm. And they knew that their true target was not Charizard, but the man in blue and his Fearow.

Fearow continued to use Agility to maintain its speed. But Murkrow, after several passes, altered its behaviour. It flapped its wings more slowly and released a thin wisp of *black* mist—*Haze*—just dense enough to envelop Fearow’s wings and neutralise the effect of Agility. It was not a smokescreen; it was a precise, almost surgical adjustment. Fearow *narrowly* avoided being hit by Murkrow’s *Pursuit*.

Fearow immediately sensed the difference; its movements lost their fluidity. The Raticate took advantage of this to charge more fiercely. Murkrow, for its part, was no longer content merely to harass: he was now diving with a more direct intent, aiming to inflict damage. Fearow, at the end of his tether, attempted to mimic the Raticate’s *Sucker Punch* with *Mirror Move* — enough to clear a path, but not enough to truly hurt Murkrow.

Whenever Charizard drew too near, a shadow shot from the bird’s eyes: *Night Shade*, ghostly, just precise enough to serve as a warning. Charizard dodged it, out of sheer strength and habit. Murkrow asked for nothing more. A thin smile. It had no intention of overwhelming it. Merely to signal that it should not interfere too much.

Gold/Richter had to step back. He gripped his hunting crop tighter. He sensed that these two Pokémon were not merely acting on orders. They wanted to break him.

The Murkrow dived one last time, lower and straighter, towards Gold/Richter. The Raticate attempted a flanking manoeuvre. Lance intercepted with Gold/Richter’s cane.

‘Your Choice’ – 03:26

After the attack, Murkrow did not fly off immediately. It hovered a few metres away, its wings half-spread, and turned its head slightly towards Gold/Richter. It stared at him for a moment, without blinking.

Then, in a clear, almost detached voice, it said:

“**Loooong live Master Giovanni!**”

The cry echoed through the already heavy air. There was no longer any irony in its tone — only the cold acknowledgement of a result achieved.

When it was all over, Lance and Gold/Richter managed to suspend the radio wave in an unstable state. Freed Electrode were still rolling menacingly through the corridors.

Lance remained silent for a long while, his gaze lost in the void. Gold/Richter, still out of breath, clutched his hunting crop without saying a word.

Around them, the lair seemed quieter than before.

Yet this silence was not peace.

It was anticipation.

End of scene

Scene – A gentilic starter

Anger Lake Beach, an autumn night

BGM ‘Ep 05 S02 0120 0248’

The lake was calm. The black water faintly reflected the stars, and the wind blowing in from the shore carried a fresh scent of reeds and damp earth. In the distance, on a small rocky outcrop, the flame on Charizard’s tail danced alone in the darkness, intermittently illuminating Lance’s motionless silhouette.

Silver stood a little way off. He had watched Lance for a moment, without approaching. Then he had looked away and headed towards Gold/Richter, as if that direction seemed both safer and more difficult to him.

Gold/Richter stood with his hands in his coat pockets. He wasn’t speaking. He was waiting.

Silver stopped a few paces away from him. He looked weary. Not just physically. There was in his silence a sort of older, more vague weariness that went back further than the night’s raid.

Gold/Richter turned his head slightly towards him.

‘You could have thought things through a bit better before taking action,’ he said softly. ‘Not to lecture you. Just… because it was risky.’

Silver lowered his eyes for a moment. A very faint, almost dry smile flitted across his lips.

“They say you’re more at ease with older people than with your peers. For me, it’s the other way round. We all have our own strengths. It’s not an excuse… just an observation.”
He sighed, then added after a pause:

“You don’t really seem to be lecturing me. Yet you said something along those lines. Why, exactly? If I’m not being too perceptive…”

Gold/Richter kept his eyes on the water for a moment before replying. His voice was calm, almost gentle."

"It is, in fact, Feraligatr's tone."

He sighed, as if he already regretted having answered.

Gold/Richter did not respond. He gazed for a moment at the dark surface of the lake.

"Your Feraligatr… at first, I hated it. I really did. But now… I see it a bit like someone from back home. How ironic."

Silver did not reply straight away; he seemed to be weighing his words.

"…You owe him your life, don't you?"

His voice was low, tinged with an irony that rang hollow.

Gold/Richter shook his head slightly.

"Not just that. It's more complicated than that."

A silence fell. Not an oppressive one, but dense enough that one could sense something was left unresolved.

Gold/Richter continued, even more quietly:

"…Taking in Pokémon from the Professors is never a good sign. You know that."

Silver paused for a moment before replying. He was staring at a spot on the water.

"So I'm risking a curse, is that it?"

There was an almost amused weariness in his voice, as if he'd heard this sort of warning far too often.

Gold/Richter did not smile.

"You've already proved otherwise. But there's still something… volatile about you."

Silver did not look up; he appeared to be turning over in his mind something he did not wish to voice.

Gold/Richter hesitated for a moment, then asked the question cautiously:

'…Why did Team Rocket unsettle you so much? Even their former leader. Even the one disguised as him.'

Silver remained silent for longer than necessary. He seemed to be weighing up whether or not to answer. When he finally spoke, it was in a low voice, almost reluctantly.

BGM: "EP01 S02 16:46–17:00"

"I… began my journey here. Partly because I wanted to… finally. Because I thought I could… do something. Against them."
Gold/Richter watched him for a moment without saying a word. When he spoke again, his voice was deeper, but still respectful.

"If you were a candidate for my gentilic in view of your Feraligatr, you ought to value your life a little more. That man… his abilities may exceed what we can imagine."

Silver remained silent for a long while. Then he replied, in an almost neutral voice, but with a hint of resigned bitterness:

“You can keep your warning. I can’t guarantee you anything. Even if I’d escaped one curse… that doesn’t mean I’d escape the others.”

He stopped there, as if he had already said too much. He turned his face away slightly, as if to pull himself together.

Gold/Richter did not press him to continue. He simply stood there at his side, without urging the matter.

Silver drew a slow breath. He looked once more in Lance’s direction, then turned his attention back to the lake. He seemed to decide that the conversation was over.

“…I’ll take my leave of you.”

He made no attempt to explain why he was leaving. He simply turned on his heel and walked away along the beach, without looking back. His pace was steady, though a little quicker than on the way there.

Gold/Richter didn’t move. He watched him go for a moment, then turned his attention back to the black waters of the lake. Charizard’s flame continued to dance in the distance, alone in the night.

End of scene

Scene – The Flame Tempered by Water

Lake of Rage beach, an autumn night

The wind had died down. Only a light breeze would occasionally ripple the lake’s black surface. In the distance, on a small rocky outcrop, the flame on Charizard’s tail burned alone in the darkness, intermittently illuminating the silhouette of Lance, standing motionless facing the water.

Gold/Richter approached unhurriedly. Lance did not turn round straight away. He had already sensed his presence.

When he spoke, his voice was low, a little weary.

‘If managing alone still troubles you, you may do without that worry.’

Gold/Richter halted a few paces behind him. He gazed at the distant flame for a moment before replying.

BGM: “EP01 S02 04:30–05:40”

“No. I’ve grown accustomed to it. The problem… is that loathsome saying.”

Lance turned his head slightly.

Gold/Richter continued, his voice even lower:

‘Long live Master Giovanni…’ That raven spoke like a ventriloquist. He did not even seem to truly revere him. And yet, that was enough to unleash the grunts. I know that feeling… but only vaguely, in

a limited way. If someone had said that to me, I'd have felt as though I was being forced to carry a burden that wasn't mine."

A silence fell. Lance did not reply straight away; he seemed to be weighing his words.

"That is also one of the reasons I stayed at your side this time," he said at last. "Team Rocket is not what it used to be. They have become more insidious. More… extreme, when it comes to someone like me, or like Green. In cases like that, experience and advice are sometimes better than a constant presence."

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze slightly. He made no move to contradict him.

Lance continued, more slowly:

"Red went through the same thing. At the time, I felt as though I'd left a child alone to face evil, despite my position. For a long time, I thought: if I'd intervened, perhaps he wouldn't have had to sacrifice so much. Professor Oak had already told me about their past atrocities. I knew that a young person like you wouldn't be able to face them alone. But it wasn't just out of penance."

He paused, his gaze lost on the water.

"It's because that same squall had spread to Johto. This time, it was one of our own children's turn to stand up to them. I couldn't just stand by and do nothing."

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment. He stared at Charizard's flame in the distance.

"…Without you I should have been undone, even so." he murmured.

Lance nodded slowly.

"That is likely. But I cannot be with you all the time. And I was wrong about one thing: even if I had supported Red earlier, he probably would not have been completely set free. Evil does not spare those we love, even when we fight. But if we do not fight… then we are sure to lose them."

A long silence fell between them.

Gold/Richter finally spoke, his voice a little lower:

"Charizard… perhaps that is why I trusted you, instinctively."

Lance let out a small sigh, almost a joyless laugh.

"I thought you'd respect that Pokémon out of respect for Red. That's partly why I brought it with me."

BGM: "EP03 S02 08:10 08:50"

Gold/Richter kept his eyes fixed on the flame.

"…I've never actually met him, Red. It's strange. I feel as though I'm following in his footsteps without ever having crossed paths with him."
Lance continued, in a calmer voice:

"Being from Johto isn't a curse. When I left for Kanto, I wanted to spread our values. But I nearly lost myself in the allure of the institution, the structure, the apparent power. And it was a child of Kanto, Red, who returned to drive back the darkness with the qualities we'd cultivated here. That made me think."

Lance fell silent for a moment. When he spoke, his voice was calmer, almost introspective.

“I did not choose him out of idolatry. His flame did not arise of its own accord. It was… tempered. As if something deeper had soothed it. Without that, it would have consumed everything. Red forged it through his choices. He accepted the love of the Girl of the Water, his own vulnerabilities, and those of others. He sees the shadow, but he chooses the light. He wasn’t the strongest. He was simply braver than many in facing evil. That’s what I respect.”

Gold/Richter did not reply; he seemed to be taking in those words in silence.

BGM: “EP06 S01 09:00–09:58”

Lance continued, in a lower voice:

“I realised something else. It wasn’t entirely my fault, nor that of my leadership. The institution isn’t inherently bad. It simply needs to be humanised, like that flame. That’s why I reformed the League. I wished to instil our values within it. Yet I sought a certain balance. Will brings a sense of spirituality and inner journey. Koga shows that tradition can exist in Kanto, too. Bruno continues to embody physical discipline. … And Karin. She possesses a rather rare insight. Yet she also knows that she depends on others to be of use.”

Gold/Richter kept his eyes fixed on Charizard’s flame. After a long silence, he spoke, his voice slightly hoarse:

“Yes. She is undeniably enlightened … Even people less clear-sighted than her. Exceptions need those around them. Without them, they eventually fade away.”

Gold/Richter added after a brief pause. “I’m not an exception like her. I’m not strong enough. But I fight all the same. Because if we don’t fight, the darkness will eventually consume those who shelter us… and us along with them. And we will perish.”

Lance regarded him for a moment, then turned his gaze towards the lake.

“Do not underestimate yourself. You are more extraordinary than you realise. Many adults never attain that wisdom. You have. I hope you will face us one day. Not because I am forcing you to. Simply because you might be the only one capable of accomplishing certain things that we can no longer do.”

Gold/Richter did not look up. He was still staring at the flame in the distance, his expression impassive.

Lance added, almost in a whisper:

“Yes. That’s why, even when we fight, there’s no guarantee we’ll be able to protect those we love. But if we don’t fight… then we’re certain to lose them.”

Silence fell once more, heavy and ancient.

Gold/Richter did not stir. He stood there, facing the lake, his gaze lost in Charizard’s distant flame. He did not look entirely convinced. Just troubled.

Lance made no attempt to add anything further.

End of scene

Scene – The Guardian of Hell and the God of Death

Goldenrod City, an autumn night

BGM: *'Please Don't Leave Me'*

Goldenrod City was relatively quiet at this late hour. The streetlamps cast a yellow glow over the damp pavements, and a few hurried passers-by were making their way home, their coat collars turned up against the cold wind.

Suddenly, the public-address system crackled. The music that usually played over the airwaves cut out abruptly. After a brief silence, a calm, measured voice rang out, broadcast on a loop across all frequencies.

Recorded voice (neutral, almost administrative tone): 'To Master Giovanni. We are sending this message from Johto. The organisation has evolved. Our methods have been updated. We believe your experience could still be of use. This message will be repeated.'

The broadcast stopped as abruptly as it had begun. A few seconds later, it started again from the beginning.

In the streets, several people had stopped in surprise. Some looked up at the loudspeakers, whilst others exchanged anxious glances.

It was then that the first snowflakes began to fall.

At first, it was just a fine, almost light snow. But very quickly, it grew heavier. Within a matter of minutes, a thick white blanket began to cover the rooftops and streets. The wind picked up, whirling the snowflakes in the light of the streetlamps. The atmosphere shifted abruptly from autumnal to wintry, as if winter had descended upon the city all at once.

Around the radio tower, several grunts and scientists in plain clothes began to cordon off passers-by who were getting too close. Their presence was discreet but firm. They didn't shout. They simply pushed back the onlookers, creating a perimeter around the building.

BGM: *'Please Don't Leave Me'* (from 00:35)

Then, from the top of the tower, a Murkrow took flight.

Its take-off was almost silent, fluid. It rose lightly into the air and quickly soared above the rooftops. Once aloft, it began to glide in slow, wide circles over the area, paying no heed to the grunts and scientists bustling about below.

Its expression was different from that of an ordinary Murkrow. More tense. More cruel. Its red eyes glowed faintly in the falling snow.

A few seconds after it took flight, a sound rose from the top floor of the tower.

At first it was distant, almost muffled by the walls and the snow. Then it grew clearer. A hoarse, irregular bark that followed no predictable rhythm. At times brief and jerky, at others long and drawn-out, as if something too large for a normal body were forcing its voice through a throat not

meant for such a task. The sound rose in waves, unpredictable, guttural, now close, now receding, as if trying to force its way through the night.

It was no ordinary animal cry. There was something ancient about that voice—too ancient. A visceral horror that seemed to come from before words, before cities, even before individual memory. Several passers-by froze in their tracks. A middle-aged man suddenly turned pale, his eyes widening as if he recognised, deep within himself, something he had never seen with his own eyes. An older woman took a step back, her hand over her mouth, tears welling up in her eyes without her knowing why. A child clung to his mother instinctively, as if the very air had become dangerous.

No one screamed. But a silent tension, almost sacred in its intensity, spread through the street. It was as though, for a few seconds, the whole town had held its breath in the face of something that should never have been heard.

The Murkrow continued to hover high in the snow, indifferent. Other Murkrow were visible further out in the night sky, patrolling too, but this one seemed to be moving in a space of its own. As if it didn't really belong to the same operation as the grunts and scientists on the ground.

The snow was falling harder and harder. The wind whipped the flakes against the shop windows and street lamps. The sound, meanwhile, continued intermittently — sometimes close, sometimes distant, always irregular, always harrowing — as if it were trying to cling to something in the collective memory, something very old, very cruel, and which had never really gone away.

The Murkrow drew one last slow circle above the radio tower, then drifted slightly away into the whiteness, without hurrying.

End of episode

Close of episode

Totals

≈ 15,000 words · 35 pp. A4 · read aloud ≈ 100 min.

Pass 1/3 — still open

Clair unique. Lake of Rage only. Blue in the stands. Fearow narrowly. Feraligatr orphan quote. Graphy: Looong live Master Giovanni! (not Long live; not Viiiive in the EN body). hunting crop ≠ whip ≠ cane. I'll take my leave of you. institution ≠ organisation (Lance on the League). P1 bis on the cut block (vote → Mahogany).

Version notes

2026-09-23 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Gyarados / levels / relay / durations moved here. Traces = address. Two Lances distinguished. Author filled. Cry frozen as Looong live Master Giovanni! Gentilic starter frozen (not gentle).

Open for what follows

Radio message to Giovanni · snow · bark (Houndoom) · Athena.

BGM credits

Pieces: Castlevania: Nocturne (Netflix), Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Traces: duration only.